

Whoever gives anything to the disciples of Zaratûšt, his reward and recompense are just as though the thing had been given by him to Zaratûšt.

From the same book (p. 266) we may quote for its resemblance to many Biblical passages,

Let no one practise ill-perpetrated deeds, even though in a wilderness when far from publicity, nor in distress, O Spîtâmân! because Aûharmazd, the observer of everything, is aware of them.

In the *Bahman. Yašt* (*SBE*, v. 197) we have something like the story of Dives and Lazarus:

I have seen a celebrity with much wealth, whose soul, infamous in the body, was hungry and jaundiced and in hell, and he did not seem to me exalted; and I saw a beggar with no wealth and helpless, and his soul was thriving in paradise, and he seemed to me exalted.

And in the same book (p. 203) there is a closer parallel with Micah 7⁶ (Matt. 10³⁶ f.):

And at that time, O Zaratûšt the Spîtâmân! all men will become deceivers, great friends will become of different parties, and respect, affection, hope, and regard for the soul will depart from the world; the affection of the father will depart from the son; and that of the brother from his brother; the son-in-law will become a beggar from his father-in-law, and the mother will be parted and estranged from the daughter.

It will be allowed that these parallels have not much of a moral either way, but they are perhaps sufficiently interesting to warrant quoting. There are doubtless others to be found for the trouble of searching: we must turn to more important matters.

I think I may claim to have presented a sufficient amount of manifestly fortuitous coincidence to justify

an attitude of great caution when dependence is alleged. The need of caution is the more obvious to us when we notice how far-reaching are the theories which have been built on the assumption of this dependence. It is perhaps as well to remember that these theories do not come from Iranian experts, but from scholars whose fame was achieved in other fields. Were we to count only the Iranists, we should even doubt whether the Parsi did not borrow from the Jew, for that was the view of Darmesteter! And it must be allowed that, however high is the authority of the protagonists in this controversy, they have nearly all come to the problem from another side, compelled to take much at second hand when dealing with Iranian texts. The real Avestan experts are very cautious indeed. From yet another point of view we learn the same lesson. Nothing impresses us more vividly, in prolonged reading of modern *religionsgeschichtlich* research, than the tenuity of the resemblances upon which historical connexion is often built up. Böklen's parallels are to a very large extent a conspicuous example in our particular field, though they are vitiated still more seriously by indifference to the date of his Parsi authorities, and to the existence—often naïvely admitted—of equally impressive parallels from other sources. The very thought of fortuitous coincidence seems hardly to enter the minds of many most learned and acute investigators.¹ The cautions of Prof. Clemen, in his

¹ I cannot resist quoting one extraordinary example touching the other side of the Aryan field. Dr Hugo Gressmann, in his most able and suggestive book on the origin of Jewish eschatology (p. 305), finds traces of mythus in the statement (Isai. 41⁸) that

introduction to *Primitive Christianity and its Non-Jewish Sources*, are very sane and very much needed, as is best shown by the multitude of comparisons alleged by first-rate scholars which he rejects. But even among those which he accepts, in a thoroughly tentative way, there are certainly some that are very doubtful. The new method needs much more testing before it will give us assured results.

Before we can begin to examine alleged parallels between Judaism and Parsism, we must obviously ask when and how contacts were made. That the Northern Israelites were deported partly to Media clearly cannot help us: later Judaism owed nothing to the Ten Tribes, whose religious apostasy caused them to vanish out of the history of Israel. What of the Jews in the Babylonian Exile? This question concerns the extent to which they had any real Zoroastrianism around them. During the "Persian period," from the reign of Darius down to the fall of the Achæmenian house, the Jews in Palestine were subject to Zoroastrian kings, as we see elsewhere. The period that follows is very dark. The Arsacide dynasty probably helped Greek influence in Judæa; and our knowledge of the conditions is so limited that we can neither form conclusions of our own nor reject on positive evidence any conjectures that ingenious speculation may attempt. What hap-

Cyrus "trod not the path with his feet"—so he translates, with a reference to Dan. 8⁵. It is to be regarded as a trait of divinity, established as such by the passage in the *Tale of Nala*, familiar to every beginner in Sanskrit, where the four gods at Damayanti's prayer distinguish themselves from their human rival by five tests of which this is one. Possibly Gressmann only means it for illustration.

pened during the Sassanian age does not concern us. I should, however, remind those who read detailed comparisons in the work of Bousset or Böklen that the antiquity of material to be found in the Pahlavi books is subject to the greatest uncertainty. We may be dealing with faithfully produced translations of old Avestan texts now lost, or with doctrines of medieval post-Sassanian Parsism. When we add to this the problems of date presented by the material collected in the Talmud, it is clear that the question of interlacing dependence is likely to be often insoluble. Happily, I am able to pass it by, and go back to Babylon as the place of contact, according to Bousset, the most important champion of the theory of Iranian influence on Judaism. It may be well to quote his summary (*Judentum*, p. 548):

The place where Parsism and Judaism came in contact was Babylon and the Babylonian plain. In Babylon, as we have said, was the centre of Jewish religion after the Exile. And there are many indications that on the other side Iranian religion had overflowed its ancient bounds and pushed its way far into the west, and in any case had attained the predominance in the old Babylonian mother-country. When Alexander the Great made his expedition to Babylon, there met him in the front rank the "Magi" or Persian priests, and in the second the Chaldæans, the priests of the Babylonian religion.¹ In Greek tradition

¹ Bousset quotes Quintus Curtius, who gives us the order of the procession which met Alexander when he entered Babylon after Arbela. After the captain of the citadel and the presents he brought came the Magi:—Magi deinde suo more carmen canentes, post hos Chaldaei Babyloniorumque non vates modo, sed etiam artifices cum fidibus sui generis ibant, laudes hi regum canere soliti, Chaldaei siderum motus et statas vices temporum ostendere. So

adapted itself, as Christianity had to do, to the postponement of the great hope. Saoshyant became a figure of the distant future linked with Zarathushtra by a miraculous birth.¹ The too dogmatic precision of Magian thought ultimately fixed a date for the coming of Saoshyant. According to the Bundahish, as worked out by E. W. West (*SBE*, xlvii. p. xxxi), his birth will take place in 2341 A.D., his two fore-runners dating respectively one and two thousand years before this: the actual Renovation is fixed for 2398 A.D., when Saoshyant reaches the age of fifty-seven. Parsi prediction, wiser than that which even in our own time gains thousands of credulous adherents in Christendom, left a good margin of time before its assertions could be put to the test of experience. *Qui vivra verra!*

As we saw above, Zarathushtra himself concentrates mainly on the individual's future destiny, and the reaction of that destiny on present conduct. That men will be judged at last for all their thoughts, words, and deeds, and that their own Self will determine a future destiny of weal or woe, is the sum of his teaching, and it is the sum of Christian teach-

¹ It is not superfluous to remark that this fact has been pressed into comparison with Isai. 7¹⁴ and the story of Matt. 1, and that by Dr P. Horn, a first-rank authority on Iranian subjects. It seems necessary, therefore, to relate the manner of Saoshyant's birth from the seed of Zarathushtra, preserved by 99,999 Fravashis in the waters of Lake *Kasaoya*, in which at last three maidens successively will be impregnated when bathing, and bring forth severally Saoshyant and his two predecessors, *Uχšyač · arəta* and *Uχšyač · nōmah*. See *SBE*, xxiii. 195 n.² I express no opinion here as to the Matthew story; but surely, in the name of science and sense, we might be spared the trouble of discussing such "parallels" as these!